

cial plug-in is required to run a video or movie file. In this case, what appears to be a legitimate plug-in could actually be spyware. Some spyware takes advantage of known vulnerabilities

in the Microsoft Windows operating system and Internet Explorer browser to secretly place spyware onto the user's computer. For example, one such method involves pushing malicious JavaScript and VBScript code to the user's Web browsers when they visit a seemingly ordinary Web page. If the user's Internet Explorer security preferences are set to the lowest levels, the code can install spyware programs on the user's hard drive and even set them so that they launch automatically the next time the user reboots. It can also insert toolbars and other objects into the browser itself, essentially changing the way the browser works in the future—all without the user's permission.

- **When users click on a deceptive or confusing pop-up:** Some pop-up screens don't actually deliver advertisements but attempt to install unwanted software on your system and change your system configurations. These pop-ups can be very clever. Instead of "To install this program, click Yes," the prompt unexpectedly reads, "To install this program, click No." After clicking on these pop-ups, the user may find that the computer now displays new bookmarks and a different home page as well as having unwanted software installed.
- **During a peer-to-peer (P2P) file transfer or software download:** Some spyware hides out in group directories on P2P networks, such as music sharing networks, and then spreads by infecting machines as users search for music selections. Other spyware is bundled with software that the user is intentionally downloading or purchasing. Some of these programs are bundled so tightly that, once installed, they are nearly impossible to get rid of.

What Do Spyware And Adware Do?

Employees may not even know that their computers have been infected until they find ads popping up all over their desktops. Or one day they may notice that their computers are working slower than usual, which happens when spyware programs are uploading information to a remote server or are downloading new ads. These are only symp-